BOOKS

Labour of Love

Arvind Krishna Mehrotra's first poetry collection after 25 years is a slim, densely packed experience

BOOK OF RAHIM & OTHER POEMS
by Arvind Krishna Mehrotra
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Everything is history. A poet-cum-general who gave away all his belongings to his soldiers. Nameless illustrators in the medieval Mughal headquarters of Burhanpur. A family home we had to flee at Partition. A father's graduation certificate, a mother's ball of wool. An ageing poet of Dilli who wants his pension from the colonial masters. The Bengali Library Lane where no one can read Bengali.

Rich with erudition and an informed imagination, fascinated by (that irreplaceable word again) history, and replete with observation, Arvind Krishna Mehrotra's first collection of poems after 25 years is a slim, densely packed experience.

To begin with, there is Abd al-Rahim Khan-i-Khanan, Akbar's multi-faceted general, whom we—products of north Indian schools—know simply as the poet Rahim. The first poem is written in the voice of a soldier in Rahim's army, who arrives too late when the poet-general is distributing his possessions among his victorious troops. 'Of what use an inkstand to a trooper?' The poems repeatedly reach out to the subaltern. *Who Were These People* on the calligraphers and illuminators of Rahim's library ends: 'No likenesses survive/ and what if they had?/ They looked like you and me./ They were you and me.'

Whether across a scholarly distance of 400 years or across the intimate gap between a compassionate householder and a trapped mouse, there is a deeply moving exercise in empathy here. Everything feels personal. The poems observe with immediacy ('As I paid him/ I noticed/ his eyelashes were whiter/ than his skull cap'); across time ('I do not understand what is written in these pages,' says the medieval bookbinder); with wit ('history is easier said than undone') and with sharp political feeling ('...The great hero winks/ and from his/ well-cushioned mouth/ there issues forth... his tips to the poor/ for living').

The book also includes translations; it is entirely possible that at this stage of Mehrotra's career, the sharp lines between translation and poetry have become irrelevant. Having earlier translated ancient Prakrit poetry and Kabir, he now turns to 35 of Rahim's poems and recreates Ghalib's elegiac diary from 1857 into condensed verse form. He brings a contemporary, sometimes conversational, quality of ease to the undeniably poetic lines.

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Ghalib's pain at the loss of his Delhi segues effortlessly into Mehrotra's sense of loss over a Lahore he never visited. The collection includes an introduction to the 'Lahore' section, describing the ancestral home from where Mehrotra's mother had fled with her infant son in 1947 ('when nations rose like party balloons in the sky'). Lahore—'Unterrestrial, ungoogleable, unreachable'—is more than evoked, its past—roads, birds, cloth traders—is felt here and now. Lost to so many of its natives, Lahore has been repeatedly invoked in post-Partition India as the children of the city became its lovers, living out the angst of separation with their personal, ancestral, cultural memories. 'Asked for the blood group, I extend a finger called Lahore.'

Acknowledging his debt to other writers for 'Ghalib: A Diary', Mehrotra says that ultimately 'origins, ours, a poem's, are mostly labours of love'. It is this capacious love which renders Mehrotra's compact, honed poems so luminous. ■

–Juhi Saklani